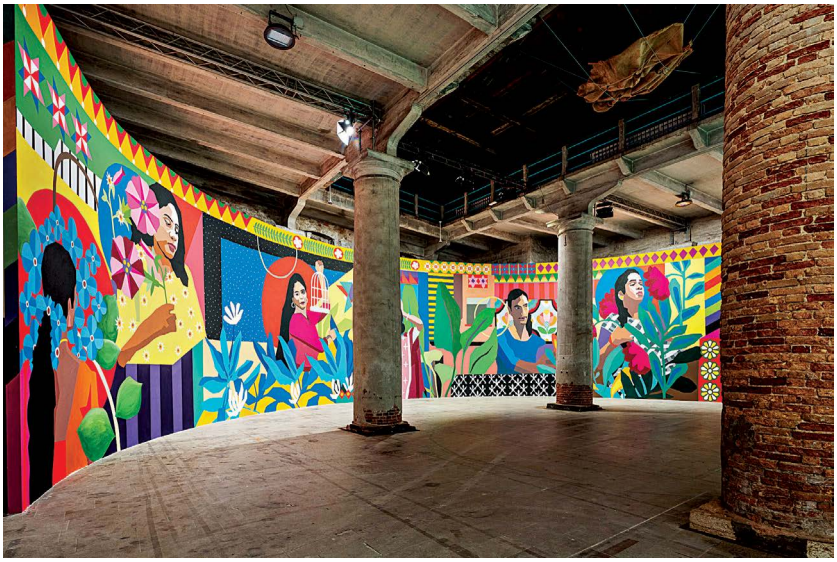


Courtesy: LA BIENNALE DI VENEZIA



Outsiders' world (Clockwise from right) 'Untitled' by F.N. Souza; 'To all the barricades...the rumour got you' by Vidha Saumya; 'Fisherman in Goa' by Bhupen Khakhar and 'Diaspore' by Aravani Art Project

ART

AN INDIAN RENAISSANCE

EVEN WITHOUT A NATIONAL PAVILION, THERE'S A SUBSTANTIAL PRESENCE OF INDIAN ART AT THE 60TH EDITION OF THE VENICE BIENNALE

The global art world's biggest and most prestigious event is currently underway in Italy. Helmed by Adriano Pedrosa, its first South American curator, the Venice Biennale's theme 'Foreigners Everywhere' speaks of our current times. It features 331 artists and collectives living in and between 80 countries. The biennale's primary focus is on artists who are themselves foreigners, immigrants or refugees—migration and decolonisation are key themes here. Given these themes and India's burgeoning art scene, the absence of a national pavilion is a missed opportunity. Nonetheless, Indian artists, and some from the diaspora, are making their presence felt at the biennale.

At the docks of Arsenale, an imposing technicolour mural dominates one of the exhibition areas. Created by the Bengaluru-based collective Aravani Art Project, 'Diaspore' (2024) is a representation of trans bodies and nature. Using signature bright colours and multifaceted images, the mural shows the different possibilities trans people should have beyond the stereotypes perpetrated by society. The mural is part of the biennale's 'Nucleo Contemporaneo' section, which is divided into two parts, diaspora activism and gender disobedience. Also featured in this section is Bhupen Khakhar (on display in the Central Pavilion) whose paintings were among the first in India—way back in the 1980s—to delve into the societal taboos around homosexuality.

The biennale's 'Nucleo Storico' section focuses on Modernism in the Global South, gathering works from 20th-century Latin America, Africa, the Middle East and Asia. Many of the Bombay Progressive Artists' Group (PAG) find representation here, such as S.H. Raza featured in the 'Abstractions' section. 'Offrande'(1986) is emblematic of his oeuvre with a distinct earthy colour palette reminiscent of the topography of Madhya Pradesh where he grew up. Another PAG co-founder, F.N. Souza, is in the 'Portraits' section with 'Untitled' (1956) depicting archetypes of priests or Catholic saints. Also featured here are Amrita Sher-Gil's 'Head of a Girl' (1937), B. Prabha's 'Waiting', Jamini Roy's untitled portrait of Lord Krishna holding a parrot and Ram Kumar's 'Women' (1953). Elsewhere in the city, the Kiran Nadar Museum of Art (KNMA) has a retrospective show devoted to India's leading modernist painter, M.F. Husain.

A recurring element of the biennale is the use of